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#WHERE THE PEOPLE ARE



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How to 🧑🏫 create a social media 💬 👥 strategy 📈



The fax technology was quickly made redundant in the '90s with the invention of a paperless version—email. At the turn of the century, communications were again revolutionized with the advent of text messaging. Our decade, too, has seen a communication revolution of its own: the rise of social media.

Social media has not only provided us with an additional means of communication but has also redefined the very meaning of social interaction. "If you are a shliach who is not present on social media today, you become irrelevant," says Rabbi Chaim Lazaroff, shliach to Uptown in Houston, Texas. "It is almost as if you are choosing not to answer the phone."

A theme the Rebbe repeatedly stressed, and an approach unique to shluchim, is not to wait for people to approach us but to actively seek them out. "If people today are on social media," says Rabbi Nosson Potash, Shliach to Cole Valley in San Francisco, California, "that's where we have to go to find them."



CREATING A SOCIAL MEDIA STRATEGY

Whether you're already on the social media bandwagon or feel like you're trying to be but haven't really managed to get on board, this article will help tailor your social media strategy to your specific demographics and needs, plus share recent developments and how you can make the most of them.

In a recent webinar he gave to shluchim via Merkos Suite 302's Shlichus Institute, Mr. Joe Apfelbaum, CEO and founder of Brooklyn-based digital marketing agency Ajax Union, outlines several steps to kickstarting an organization into the world of social media and maintaining an effective presence online.

STEP 1

IDENTIFY YOUR GOALS

"Many people start out on social media because they feel that's what they should be doing," Apfelbaum says, "but they don't have a clear picture of what they are trying to achieve. Your time is your currency—you should know why you're spending it before you dive in."

BE SPECIFIC

The most important key to identifying your goals is to be extremely specific. The more defined a goal is, the easier it is to attain and the better it can be measured to see if it has been met.

"I want to create awareness" is not a specific goal. How will you measure whether or not you've "created awareness"? How much awareness do you want to create? What exactly constitutes awareness?

Even a more specific goal like "I want to attract more people to my event" is not narrow enough. How many more people do you want to attract? 10 people? 50 people? 1,000 people? The goal needs to be clearly defined: *I want x more people to come to my next event.* Having an exact idea of what you are looking to achieve makes the goal attainable and allows you to measure how successful you have been in reaching it.

BE REALISTIC

Another point to bear in mind when setting goals, Apfelbaum says, is to be realistic. "People get upset when their page only has a few hundred likes, or when their posts only get a couple shares," he says. "They want to be celebrities with tens of thousands of followers. Think about it, though—you're

not looking to become a celebrity. You're looking to stay in touch with your community. If your community base is only so big, then that's the only following you need."

Start small, he says, and over time your following will grow. "Make a small, attainable goal: *I want to engage five people on Facebook this week.* Then you can measure your success and see what works. Is it photos that attract my people? Is it engaging conversation? Inspirational quotes? Over time, you will figure out the kind of content that interests your people; you'll be able to create a more effective strategy by zeroing in on those mediums." (If you have a "page" as opposed to a "profile," the amount and kinds of engagement generated by your page's posts, along with a lot of other useful information about the trends on your page, can be viewed by clicking "Insights" at the top of your page.)

STEP 2

FIND & LEVERAGE THE RIGHT PLATFORM

Once you've defined clear and attainable goals, you have to identify the best platform to use to reach those goals. Each social media platform has a different interface and targets a different demographic.

Facebook is by far the most actively used social media site. It is a perfect platform for creating online conversation, sharing photos, and hosting events. If you are looking to attract the younger crowd, who respond better to photos and videos, Instagram or Snapchat might be more ideal. If your target audience is more savvy—typically people involved in tech, journalism, politics, or

sport—Twitter would be the best place to find them. Posting on LinkedIn is a great way to create a professional appearance and target people in the professional world.

“Think to yourself,” says Apfelbaum, “where are the people I’m trying to reach?” If your people are primarily on Facebook, then using other platforms is a waste of your time.”

Many shluchim choose Facebook as their primary social media platform, finding it the most effective in terms of reaching people. Rabbi Lazaroff maintains a very active Facebook account. “I tracked the RSVPs to a recent event we had at Chabad,” he said. “More than 90 percent of those who registered reached our site through our Facebook invite. Ninety percent! I’ve come to realize that this is where my community can be found.”

Other shluchim have embraced Twitter and reach thousands of people they would otherwise have no contact with. Rabbi Shmuli Brown (known by his Twitter handle @UniRabbi), shliach to Liverpool University, has close to 3,500 people following his Twitter account. “I deal mainly with students on campus who are very active on Twitter. Often, the messages I tweet are retweeted again and again and, before I know it, my message has reached tens of thousands of people.”

There are advantages to Twitter over Facebook, Brown says, in terms of the amount of people you can reach. “Facebook is more of a community-oriented platform, whereas Twitter is really a way to reach the wider world. The sheer amount of hafotzas hamaayanos that can be done over Twitter is mindblowing.”

STEP 3

CREATE YOUR ONLINE VOICE

Social media is exactly that—social—so your interactions with people should be similar to the way you would interact with them in real life. “People want to see *you*,” Apfelbaum says, “not some created image you’re looking to project.”

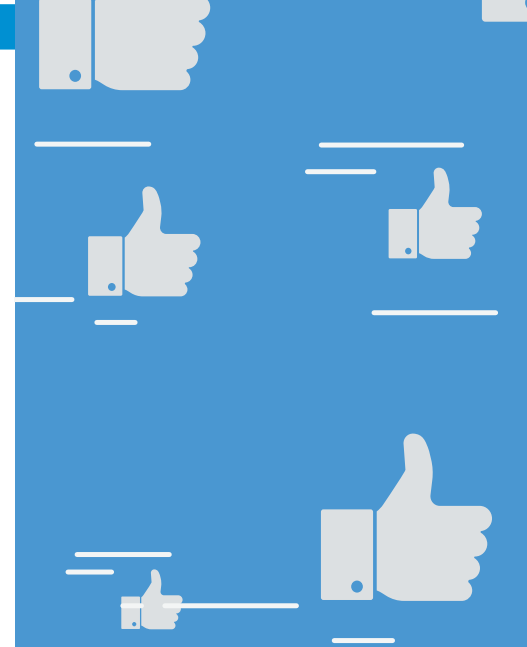
Explains Rabbi Mordechai

Many 🧑🏻🧑🏻🧑🏻🧑🏻 start out on 🧑🏻💬 because they 🧑🏻 that’s what they should be doing, but they don’t have a 👁️✅📷 of what they are trying to 📈. Your 🕒 is your 💰—you should know why you’re 🧑🏻🛒 it before you 🧑🏻 in.

Lightstone, Chabad.org’s social media editor, “If people who meet you are used to you being funny—be funny in your online presence. If you tend to engage in more meaningful conversation, bring that conversation to your Facebook feed.”

“Everyone in this world is looking for relationships,” Apfelbaum says. “We are looking to connect with other people and share our lives with them. If I just post about my business and promote my products, people are not going to be interested. They want to see what’s going on with me.”

Potash has a specific imagery that helps him decide what and how to share on Facebook: a coffee date. “When I’m sitting down to meet



A good 🙌 way to 🤔
about 💬 on
Facebook, says
Potash, is to
imagine yourself 🙌
someone for ☕.

someone over a coffee, I don't barrage him with a list of programs I'm hosting that week," he says. "I catch up with that person; I talk about myself and my family. I'm working on creating a rapport with that person. I do the same thing with my Facebook account—only with thousands of coffees a day!"

"If Facebook is just your broadcasting platform, people will lose interest, and they'll stop reacting to your posts," Lazaroff says. "You have to share your human side on Facebook. If you thought of an interesting idea, write a post about it. If you put Tefillin on with someone, share a photo and tag the person. You want to give people the feeling that they are living their day together with you."

Aside from developing personal relationships with people this way, sharing your human side on social media can lead to direct "shlichus" benefits as well. "Now, when I invite people to a shiur or to an event, they see a *person* behind the invitation," Lazaroff explains. "It's not just a broadcast or a mass email. It's that rabbi, who they know so much about and who has shared so much with them, who is inviting them over to learn."

STEP 4 POST ENGAGING CONTENT

In today's world of instant everything, you have to be way more engaging than you might think is necessary if you want to attract people's attention. "Think about what kind of things will get people interested," Apfelbaum

says, "and work on sharing that type of content. Create a campaign that you know people will share. Collaborate with other organizations—tag them, share their pages, comment on their posts—and you'll find people responding to yours."

When it comes to business marketing, the number one advice is to use your platform to offer something valuable to your followers, a reason they *want* to tune in to you, and not just market your product.

Visuals, statistics show, create more than 12 times the traffic of regular posts. Videos posted are 12 times more likely to be shared by others on social media. Posts with photos have a 200 percent greater click-rate than posts with plain text.

Apfelbaum challenges shlichim to post selfies of themselves going about their daily routines. "People want to see what you're up to—they want to feel a part of your organization. If you're looking for engagement—there is no better way than posting pictures of yourself."

Another effective tool is to post short videos. "Post a 30-second clip of Hebrew school that day, or of minyan, or of a class you gave," he says. "This is the kind of content people want to see."

FREQUENCY

How often should you post on Facebook? "If you post once a week about your weekly shiur, make sure you post each week," says Apfelbaum. "If you post more often, that's even better, but just make sure to be consistent about it."

Obviously, the more often you can post the better. Think of it in terms of radio advertising—the more often you hear an ad, the more the message stays in your head. "For your personal account,

I would suggest posting at least once a day—more if you can," Lightstone says. "For your organization page, the minimum should be three times a week, but it's best if you can post daily."

"You don't want to open a page and then leave it inactive for long periods of time," Lightstone explains. "It's better not to start on a platform at all until you've figured out how to maintain a consistent presence."

One way to make it easier to keep your content coming is to schedule it in advance; line up a number of engaging articles, pictures, and videos, and have them posted automatically to your page. There is a range of programs—Hootsuite, Buffer, Sprout Social, and more—that can coordinate scheduled posts across all your social media platforms.

Says Apfelbaum, remembering that you are creating relationships with people online is key. "The more you post, the more authentic you are. The more engaging content you share, the greater relationships you will build."¹

¹ For more on how to use social media as a means for actual hafotzas hamaayonos, see *Compass Magazine* vol. 14, "#GoWithTheFlow?"



PRACTICAL FACEBOOK TIPS

FACEBOOK LISTS

Say you only want the parents of your bar mitzvah club to read your club-related posts. Facebook allows users to create custom lists and to make the posts visible only to the people on that list. Facebook automatically generates some lists for you, such as work, family, community, etc., but you can create unlimited custom lists as well, and tailor each one to target a specific crowd.

FACEBOOK GROUPS

Create a Facebook group called Bar Mitzvah Club, add those parents who send their children, and post anything relevant to that specific group. When posting to a group, only members who are invited to the group will see the posts, and the members can post there, too.

PAID AND TARGETED ADVERTISING

When you post something to your page, only people who have liked your page in the past will see your post. For relatively new Facebook pages, with only a few page likes, it can be very difficult to have any of your posts actually be seen.

Paid page advertising will get your page shared with people who have not yet liked your page. This can be a great way to start building recognition. You can also pay to have specific posts “boosted” to reach a greater number of people.

The way to best capitalize on advertising expenses is by creating targeted ad lists. You can limit your ads to people of a certain demographic—age, location, gender, etc., or of certain interests—religion, Torah, Chabad, etc. This ensures that the money you spend is going toward reaching relevant people who *you* want to reach.

One option for targeting your ads is to use Facebook’s automatically generated lists to direct your posts to a specific audience before paying to have it boosted. A slightly more advanced—but also more efficient—way to target specific audiences is to use Facebook Ad Manager. By logging onto Facebook.com/business, you can follow an in-

depth advertising wizard that will help you define your advertising goals and create a tailored list to suit your needs. The wizard is fairly comprehensive and simple to use, and once the lists are created they can be used for all further posts.

FACEBOOK LIVE

In April of 2016, Facebook launched a new and exciting feature: Facebook Live. Before the launch of this feature, you could only post pre-recorded content—pictures, information, or videos. Facebook Live introduced the ability to stream whatever you are doing—live—to your Facebook feed.

Although Facebook Live can be used for a wide range of purposes, it can prove extremely beneficial in the shlichus arena. Say you're hosting an event or teaching a class, and there are people who aren't able to make it in person. With Facebook Live, they can stay wherever they are and tune in online to the event or class as it's going on in real time. All you need is your phone and an internet connection, and you can host a live hookup to whatever you are doing. 📺

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